Choosing Hope

By Kaitlin Roig-Debellis and Robin Fisher

KAITLIN: **(Pg 81)** The morning sun rising over Long Island Sound on December 14 was even more breathtaking than usual. My step had a skip as I pushed out the door and walked to my car to head to school. Could life get any better? I was twenty-nine years old, engaged to the man of my dreams, and working in a job I would have done for free, I loved it so much. **(Pg 1-3)** I live every day wishing I could go back to December 13, 2012. Back to who I was, who my kids were, back to our school and the life I would never in a million years have changed. The Sandy Hook Elementary School massacre was the worst mass murder of schoolchildren in the United States since the Bath School bombing in 1927. Six of my colleagues and twenty first-graders -- six and seven-year-olds who were still learning to tell time, and count to 120, and spell 100 words – were murdered that morning.

INTRODUCTION

Kaitlin Roig-Debellis wanted to be a teacher from a young age, and relished working with children ever since she was allowed to babysit. After seven years as a first-grade teacher, her life changed dramatically. Choosing Hope is her story . . . assisted by Robin Gaby Fisher.

KAITLIN: **(Pg 82-94)** It was 7:45. I parked my car in the teachers' lot, reached for my pile of books and papers, and proceeded to the school's main entrance, through the double doors, past the main office, and across the hall to my classroom. Dropping my books on my desk, I went right to work. Our reading specialist was coming to observe my class and I wanted to make sure everything was ready for her visit. I was so busy that I hadn't even taken the time to greet a group of my coworkers as they walked back and forth between the main office and a nearby conference room where a meeting was being held. By the time the buses arrived and my students filed into our classroom, a few minutes before nine, I felt ready for the day. *(to students)* Good morning, Fantastic Friends!

CHILDREN: Good morning, Miss Roig!

KAITLIN: After attendance, my students settled in to do their morning work until I played the

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song to signal morning meeting. *(sing)* "Oh, what a beautiful morning! Oh, what a beautiful day. *(return to narration)* They gathered around my chair, excited to get started. I picked up a pile of cards, each one with a different greeting written on it, and fanned them out the way a magician does a deck of playing cards before a magic trick. The cards said things like *¡Hola!* and *Bonjour* and *High Five!* One student picked a card from the deck, and whatever was written on it was the day's greeting. That morning, the card chosen was *Ball Roll,* a special card and one of the kids' favorites, which meant they got to roll a ball to one another as they said their good mornings. The student seated next to me was always excited about being able to greet the teacher. That morning, it was the little girl with cascades of brown curly hair who always wore pink.

LITTLE GIRL: Good morning, Miss Roig.

KAITLIN: I loved that moment. You can't help but be happy after looking into the eager eyes of a sweet, smiling first-grader. After that, we moved on to sharing time. Because the Christmas season and Hanukkah were upon us, the theme that day was "Our Holiday Traditions." One of my students, a rambunctious boy with chestnut--colored eyes and foot-long lashes, smart as a whip, had been chattering about Christmas since September, and now it was just eleven days away. He was wild with anticipation. He told the story of his cousins coming to spend the holidays, squealing as he spoke. The others talked about making cookies, and visiting Santa, and listening for reindeer, and lighting the menorah, and visits with family members and friends. *(to students)* Let's get excited about today! You're going to shine! *(to audience)* It was 9:30, fifteen minutes before the "big test" . . . but we never got that far.

First comes the initial blast of gunfire, then the sound of shattering glass. The hair on my arms stands up. I know right away what I am hearing. Columbine is happening in the place we called Pleasantville. How can it be? Someone with a weapon is shooting their way into our perfect school. My classroom is the first one in the building. *We are in grave danger -- sitting targets.* I jump up, run to the door, pull it closed, and switch off the lights. I can't lock the door. My keys are clear across the

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room, on top of my desk and a locked door is no match for a magazine of bullets. If we're going to live, we have to find a hiding place. Fast. I look around the classroom. My students don't seem to understand what is happening. One, the little girl I call our fashionista, because she wears things like leopard prints and leggings, stands there smiling. I can't tell if she is somehow oblivious to the sounds or scared frozen. The windows don't open wide enough for a first-grader to climb through, and who knows what or who is waiting outside? Evil is coming for us and there's nowhere to go.

Where can we hide? Where can we hide? There's only one place. The bathroom-a tiny, tiny first grade-sized lavatory with only a toilet and a toilet-paper dispenser inside. Its dimensions are about the size of two first-grade desks pushed together. Maybe three feet by four feet. There is so little space that the sink is on the outside, in the classroom. I have never even been inside the bathroom before. An adult wouldn't fit comfortably. How in God's name will I get sixteen of us in there? It is our only chance. The impossible will have to become possible. *(to students)* Into the bathroom! Now!

CHILD 1: In there? How?

CHILD 2: Why?

CHILD 3: What do you mean, Miss Roig?"

KAITLIN: *(to students)* Bathroom! Now! *(to audience)* They understand that the teacher means business. I rush them toward the back of the classroom. Shots are being fired outside our classroom door. There's no time. "Hurry!" I say, pushing them into the tiny space. "Hurry!" But I know that no matter how quickly my students respond, it will still take two or three minutes to get everyone inside, minutes I feel sure we don't have.

We all push into the bathroom, and when there isn't a millimeter of space left, I begin lifting my students and piling them inside. I place one student, then two, then three on top of the toilet and hoist up my littlest girl and sit her on the toilet-paper

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dispenser. We are all crushed together with not even enough room left to take a deep breath. I reach out to pull the door closed, but just before I do, I reach outside for a large storage cabinet on wheels that is nearby and pull it as close as I can to the front of the bathroom door, hoping that maybe it will conceal it.

My heart pounds against my chest, but I cannot afford to lose my composure, not if we are to have any chance of getting out of this alive. First-graders model their teacher's behavior. If I panic, they'll all panic, and we'll be dead. *(to students)* Now, we have to be absolutely quiet. We can't say a word.

Someone shouts, "Shooter! Stay put!" Is that our principal? The school nurse? Another teacher? The sounds are too muffled to tell. Then, ear-splitting, rapid-fire shots, like a machine *gun -- di-di-di-di-di-di-di-di-di-di-di-di -- over* and over and over. My students stay perfectly quiet. They understand that someone very bad is searching for us and in order for us not to be discovered they stay perfectly quiet. In our silence, we hear voices -- muffled voices. People are pleading for their lives. "No! Please, no! Please! No!" With the inescapable sounds of carnage happening all around us, my little ones are feeling desperate.

CHILD 4: *(whispering)* What is happening?"

KAITLIN: My fashionista begins to cry. I cup her face in my hands and look into her teary eyes. *(to student)* We're going to be okay. *(to audience)* The boy who straddles the top of the toilet is shaking so hard that he accidently flushes. Once, then again. We all hold our breath. *Shhhhhhhhhh!!!!! Did the shooter hear?* I look at the boy and his face says it all. *I'm scared and I'm sorry and I don't know what to do.*

CHILD 5: *(whispering)* Miss Roig, I don't want to die today.

CHILD 6: *(fighting tears)* I just want my mom.

CHILD 7: *(whispering)* I don't want to die before Christmas.

CHILD 8: *(whispering)* I'll lead the way! I know karate.

KAITLIN: *(to audience)* Hadn't it been only moments ago that he told us the story of finding a dollar under his pillow for his two front teeth? *(to students, gently)* No. There are bad

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guys out there and we need to wait for the good guys to come. It's going to be okay. We're going to be okay . . . I need you to know that I love you all very much. *(to audience)* In comforting them, I also brought comfort to myself. *(to students)* Anyone who believes in the power of prayer needs to pray right now.

(close eyes and pray) Suggested "prayer" – Not in the original text. You may insert your own prayer here if desired or simply pray in silence for a few beats. Check the rules governing your tournament regarding addition of "transition/additional" words.

[(softly) God, we are scared. But You are there. Even when we don't know what to say, we can just pray, "Help me, God, I'm so scared." Thank You for this day, even though it's not been the best day. Help us. Help us to see and remember all of the good things You have blessed our lives with. In Jesus' Name, Amen.]

It's been quiet for a while now. Eerily quiet. I wonder if the gunman is lurking outside our door, waiting for us to feel safe enough to come out of the bathroom and fall into his trap. *If the good guys were coming, they would have been here by now, wouldn't they? Why is it so deathly quiet?* I think about my students' parents and the unimaginable grief they will suffer because I was powerless to save their children. My worst fear is that I will see my class murdered before I die and I won't be able to stop it. All we can do now is wait. . . An eternity passes. Some of my kids are becoming impatient.

CHILD 9: I'm hot, Miss Roig. Can we please get out?"

KAITLIN: Several say they need to go to the bathroom. For the most part, though, they are quite content to be quiet if it means the bad guy can't find us. I wonder what is happening outside. Then, from the other side of the wall, come the voices of people who are barking orders. I hear them clearly.

VOICE 1: Don't look up. Don't open your eyes. Walk Quickly.

KAITLIN: Oh, *God. Is there more than one shooter? Are they kidnapping people? What is going to happen to us? My heart races in my chest. My kids look up at me. (to students)* Shhhhhhhh. *(to audience)* We have been in the bathroom for a very long time. At least forty-five minutes.

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A knock comes at the door and we all stiffen with fear. *(put index finger to lips as a signal to the children)* I fear that if we make any noise, the shooter will realize that the teacher has hidden her whole class in here. *(to student in a whisper)* Ask who's there. *(to audience)* I don't want the shooter to know that there are sixteen terrified people huddled together behind the bathroom door.

CHILD 10: *(voice quivering)* Who is it?"

VOICE 2: *(a kind voice)* Hey, little fella. We're here to help you. Unlock the door.

KAITLIN: *No way!* Why in the world would I trust the words of a faceless stranger? No way am I going to risk opening the door for a killer. *(to the person outside the door)* If you really are the police, I need your badge. *(to audience)* Seconds pass. A badge is slipped under the door. I pick it up and examine it. It looks fake, like a play badge that one of my students might wear. I desperately want for it to be real, but I'm not convinced. *(to person outside the door)* This doesn't look real. I don't believe you. *(to audience)* I look around at my kids and I know they are thinking what· I am. *Please let this be the good guys.* One little girl is choking back tears. I take her face in my hands and smile. If she starts to cry, the others will cry. I can't let that happen, not until I find out who is on the other side of the door. *(to person outside the door)* If you are the police and you're here to help us, then you should have the key to this door. Or you should be able to get it. *(to audience)* A few more minutes pass before I hear the rattle of keys. I hear the scraping sound of a key going into the lock. It doesn't work. Another key, another failed attempt. Five. . . six . . . seven tries. My stomach churns with each twist of the lock. My students' eyes are wide.

The tenth key works. The knob turns and the door pushes in. I see an army of uniforms-people dressed in black and wearing helmets and carrying big guns, peering in at us. A SWAT team is in our classroom. The good guys are here. They pull us out of the bathroom, at first, one by one, until there is enough room for us to move on our own. Our heroes lead us out of the classroom and guide us in the opposite direction of the bodies in the hallway and the blood-stained floor. I grab the hands of the two students closest to me and follow

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the instructions to "Go. Fast." We rush the students down the hall and out of the building. "Where is the bad guy?" I ask as we make our way to the firehouse. *Is he still lurking here, somewhere, ready to hurt us?* They assure me that we are safe. I say "Thank you" over and over . . .

Thank you for finding us in that tiny bathroom . . . Thank you for being the good guys . . . Thank you for saving our lives.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kaitlin Roig-DeBellis
ISBN: 978-0399174452
Publisher: GP Putnam's Sons
Date (Month/Year): Oct 2015

AWARD HISTORY

2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2022 National Qualifier - MS
2023 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier – MS
2025 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

Oh, What a Beautiful Morning – lyrics and music can be found here:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8cCrRGYK2rY

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